

See also: The Geneva Conventions 152–155 ■ The Nuremberg trials 202–209
■ The United Nations and International Court of Justice 212–219

Europe's **nations** are **prostrated** by **World War I**;
another great **war** is **unthinkable**.



The **US** briefly **emerges** as the **world's peacemaker**,
championing democracy and a **league of nations**.



France and Britain insist that **Germany's might**
must be **curtailed** to stop it from starting another war, and that
Germany must pay for the **damage** that it has done.



The **Treaty of Versailles** formally ends the war and
compels Germany to **disarm, surrender territory**, and
make **huge reparations** to the Allied powers.

the war, it should bear the burden. So the Treaty of Versailles imposed two major conditions on Germany.

The first condition of the treaty was financial. Germany was to pay reparations of 132 billion marks. This was on top of its vast war debts of around 150 billion marks. It also had to surrender almost all of its iron-ore and coal resources, as well as 13 percent of its territory, where about 10 percent of its people lived.

Germany also had to disarm. Its armies, 3.8 million strong in 1914, were to be cut to 100,000; and it had to give up most of its navy and all of its larger merchant ships. The Rhineland, in the west of Germany, was to become a demilitarized zone policed by Allied troops, and all of Germany's overseas colonies were to be given up.

Forced to sign the treaty, Germany was left both humiliated and impoverished, its economy ruined, its emperor exiled, and its people starving. Even at the time, it was recognized that such punitive demands on a defeated people could only provoke bitterness.

Dire consequences

Germany's punishment proved to be disastrous for the long-term success of the peace treaty. The country might have recovered if the Great Depression had not plunged it into further economic misery, to the benefit of Hitler. He was not an inevitable product of the Treaty of Versailles, but his rise would have been unthinkable without it. Aiming to end the war to end all wars, the Versailles Treaty paved the way for World War II and the Holocaust. ■

The League of Nations

The world's determination to make impossible any future conflict on the scale of World War I was epitomized by the creation in Geneva in 1920 of the League of Nations. It was to be an international force for cooperation and security between nations.

Although inspired by US president Woodrow Wilson, the League was undermined from the start by the refusal of the US, reverting to isolationism, to join it and by the perception that it was a Franco-British attempt to justify colonial dominance.

The League of Nations soon proved toothless, a well-meaning body with no effective means of imposing its judgments and frequently unable to agree on a collective course of action. At its peak in 1935, it could claim only 58 members, many of whom were ambivalent; some joined the League for only a few years.

False start or not—it was officially disbanded in 1946—the League was the template for the United Nations in 1945.



This is not a peace,
it is an armistice for
twenty years.

Marshal Ferdinand Foch
French general (1851–1929)

